Fahien



During the reign of Chandragupta II, the Buddhist monk Fahien visited India. His travel accounts provided us information about the socio-economic, religious and moral conditions of the people of the Gupta age. According to Fahien, the people of Magadha were happy and prosperous, that justice was mildly administered and there was no death penalty. Gaya was desolated. Kapilavasthu had become a jungle, but at Pataliputra people were rich and prosperous.

assumed to have been Narasimha Gupta I. He was himself attracted towards Buddhism. He was paying tribute to Mihirakula but was distressed by his hostility towards Buddhism. So he stopped paying tribute. Though Baladitya succeeded in imprisoning him, Mihirakula turned treacherous and drove away Baladitya from Magadha. After Baladitya, the great Gupta Empire faded away. The last recognised king of the Gupta Empire was Vishnugupta.

Gupta Polity

The divine theory of kingship (the concept that king is the representative of God on earth and so he is answerable only to God and not to anyone else) was practised by the Gupta rulers. The Gupta kings wielded enormous power in political, administrative, military and judicial spheres. The Gupta king was assisted by a council of *mantris* (ministers). The council consisted of princes, high officials and feudatories. A large number of officials were employed by the Gupta rulers to carry on the day-to-day administration of the country. High-ranking officials were called *dandanayakas* and *mahadandanayakas*.

The Gupta Empire was divided into provinces known as *deshas* or *bhuktis*. They were administered by the governors, designated as *uparikas*. The province was divided into districts such as *vishyas and* they were controlled by the officers known as *vishyapatis*. At the village level, there were functionaries such as *gramika* and *gramadhyaksha*.

The extensive empire shows the important role of military organisation. Seals and inscriptions mentioned military designations as *baladhikrita* and *mahabaladhikrita* (commander of infantry and cavalry respectively). The system of espionage included spies known as *dutakas*.

Society and Economy

Land and Peasants

Nitisara, authored by Kamandaka, emphasises the importance of the royal treasury and mentions various sources of revenue. The military campaigns of kings like Samudragupta were financed through revenue surpluses. Land tax was the main revenue to the government. The condition of peasants was pathetic. They were required to pay various taxes. They were reduced to the position of serfs.

6th Std History_Term 3_EM_Unit3.indd 115 06-11-2019 10.56.35 AM